across the prairies, and then drove southwards along the west coast of the US to Yuba City, San Francisco, Sacramento, Los Angeles, and down to San Diego and back to Ottawa by re-entering the prairies at Winnipeg. During those trips I met several old friends and relatives and developed new friends and contacts, with whom I remained in touch even after my return to New Delhi.

During that period the Indian community in Canada, comprising mostly Sikhs, were a satisfied lot and were earnestly involved in trying to improve their socio-economic status. In the process, they were contributing their bit to the development of a multicultural society in the country they had chosen as their new home. Other than the normal jostling for the management of gurudwaras in the two major cities of Vancouver and Toronto, for an average Sikh the concept of Khalistan was a non-issue – if not a bit of a joke – not worthy of attention.



Fate sometimes brings you face to face with falsehood wrapped in layers of obfuscation. For an average and casual observer, in awe of the reputation and status of the creator of the falsehood, it is difficult to see through the outer layers and identify the bare bones of the hidden skeleton of falsehood. In that context, I am perhaps no exception.

The falsehood I refer to was designed to make the people of India believe that a fairly large number of the Sikh diaspora from Canada, the US and the UK nursed pro-Khalistan sentiments. Which started to surface 1981 onwards; that soon such feelings started to rub off on a certain segment of the Sikh population in Punjab; that differences between Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and the moderate Akali Dal leadership led by Harchand Singh Longowal were the outcomes of their differing religious/ideological perceptions, with which the Congress party had nothing to do; that the law and order situation in Punjab resulted from these differences and from Bhindranwale-inspired extremist activities alone; that the Central government under Indira Gandhi and the Punjab government under Darbara Singh up till 5 October 1983 and thereafter under